

attack. Efforts were made to revamp our security apparatus and for a year there was a lull before a fresh attack showed how vulnerable India still is.

However, in the last 10 years, India did indeed undergo a redeeming makeover in its global outlook. It discarded the mindset of Third Worldism and got out of the entrapment of anti-imperialism. India's nuclear deal with Washington was the logical culmination of a process started by the previous BJP government, who recognised the fact that world's two great democracies should be natural allies—that they should be together on the right side of history. Naturally, we may ask the inevitable question: Is the axis of global power shifting to Asia? Maybe, but I believe not in a hurry. China's



economic growth is the decade's most inspirational story but as long as it continues to disguise its First World economic power in Third World clothing, it won't acquire the Superpower status it aspires to. In any geo-political order, Beijing will continue to have a mighty presence but living with the inscrutable and frequently unscrupulous dragon will be a challenge for Washington as well as New Delhi.

The momentous events of the past decade give us intimations of the future. The three big issues staring at us are global terror, international financial fragility, and the environmental threat. If we are to learn anything from the past it is simply this: We are all in it together. Take the war on terror. It has reached a critical phase in Afghanistan, and it can't always remain the war of America or Britain alone. What's more, short term political interest may force President Obama to abandon the cause. We continue to be reminded that India too has a stake there. The world cannot afford to abandon the war against religious terror as the headache of a few. The world should also be honest in iden-

tifying the dubious bargainers who manipulate their status as a frontline ally in the war on terror. For India, still under attack, there can't be justice as long as our double-dealing neighbour remains a patron of extraterritorial terror.

If we are a bit more optimistic, the colour of the decade was not red but green. In spite of the initial euphoria about "Hopenhagen", the summit at Copenhagen failed to form an international solidarity on protecting an endangered planet. Still, it was a decade that saw the birth of a new green consciousness. We are all now stakeholders in an endangered planet. As for the marketplace, the economy may be on the road to recovery, but are we any wiser? Certainly, in spite of the collapse, we cannot return to a state-controlled economy. The free market model has not failed. It has been caused by the greed of a few. As one commentator who twisted the Churchillian phrase and said: "Never have so few destroyed so many". There was, of course, a failure of regulation. But, the lesson to be learnt from the global meltdown is that financial instruments and markets are global while regulation is local. This needs to change into a stable framework of international co-operation.

The unknowns of the coming years only exaggerate our expectations. The only certainty is that a leadership that is not steeped in the past alone can make the future safer. I mean a leadership that is not apologetic about idealism and is willing to act on those ideals with clarity and determination. Our expectations range from political to economic, from the safety of nations to the safety of the planet itself. And I believe India should be in the forefront in leading the world on many fronts in the coming decade. With our youthful population, we are a nation pregnant with potential.

Ladies and Gentlemen, I may not expect a great deal from our political leaders, forgive me for my cynicism. I, though, expect a lot from our speakers. They include the man who is making this country more secure than ever before; a man from the fastest growing city of the world who showed how you build a miracle on sand and deal with the new challenge it faces; the world's foremost expert on risk of probability who has challenged the conventional thinking of economics; the co-founder of the largest social networking site and one of the brains behind the initial Obama-mania; gurus from the spiritual world; the performers from the Indian Cabinet and the new leader of the Indian right; top stars from the cyberspace to tell you how our lives will be transformed in the future; the king of Hollywood and the superstar of Bollywood who continue to reinvent the art of moviemaking; the world famous Indian novelist who is also one of the sharpest public intellectuals of our times. And many more whose inventive spirit never rests. They make my expectations greater, if not for the new decade, at least for the next two days.

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